

BOMBED OUT
A damaged house after a 'drone' attack at Koutruk village in Imphal West; (inset) remnants of a missile

NG THREATS: FACT OR FICTION?

On Sept. 6, a 70-year-old priest was killed when a rocket landed in the residential compound of ex-CM M. Koireng Singh in the Moirang area of Bishnupur district. Manipur Police allege that Kuki villagers and militants are using RPGs and modifying drones to drop explosives

But both Kuki groups and former Assam Rifles D-G Lt. Gen. Pradeep Nair dismiss the claims. Nair says the projectiles may be homemade "pumpi guns". Kuki National Organisation spokesperson Seilen Haokip says "a rocket launcher attack is an implausible idea. This is an orchestrated effort by the state government to malign the Kukis". Nair's comments were refuted by Manipur Police and even Congress MP Angomcha B. Akoijam

them in key areas, including Kuki-dominated Churachandpur. The decision sparked fierce protests from the Kuki community, which has openly expressed its preference for the Assam Rifles.

MISSING POLITICAL WILL

Amidst the web of allegations and counter-allegations, the Centre's striking indifference is impossible to overlook. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has not visited the state in the 16 months since the violence began, and prefers to avoid commenting on the crisis. His deputy, home minister Shah, has not done any better. Even as over 6,500 firearms and thousands of rounds of ammunition have been looted, action on disarmament remains muted.

The leadership vacuum has only intensified the conflict, reviving long-dormant insurgencies in the valley. A chargesheet filed by the National Investigating Agency (NIA) in a Guwahati court on May 14 revealed that the National Socialist Council of Nagaland (Isak-Muivah) or NSCN (I-M) has been aiding banned valley insurgent outfits like the Kanglei Yaol Kanba Lup (KYKL) and the People's Liberation Army of Manipur (PLA), allowing them to infiltrate into India to exploit the ongoing ethnic turmoil. "Disarmament on both sides is essential, and a framework for dialogue must be established," emphasises social activist Ratika Yumnam.

THE LEADERSHIP VACUUM HAS REVIVED LONG-DORMANT INSURGENCIES IN THE VALLEY. AN NIA CHARGESHEET CONFIRMS THE INFILTRATION BIDS BY BANNED OUTFITS

However, the crisis extends beyond law and order. The Kukis are now demanding a separate administration. "We have been driven out of the Meitei areas, many Kukis have been killed, and our homes and churches destroyed. Over 40,000 are now homeless. We can no longer stay under the same roof as the Meitei. We have demanded a political separation in the form of a Union Territory (UT) with legislature under Article 239A of the Constitution," says Ginza Vualzong of the Indigenous Tribal Leaders Forum.

The Centre is well aware that even entertaining this demand could have seismic consequences in the valley. Despite claims of backdoor negotiations, the irony is that many key stakeholders have been excluded from the talks. "The seven Kuki MLAs last met home minister Shah in May 2023. Since then, despite repeated requests, we have not been granted an audience," says Paolienlal Haokip, a tribal MLA, underlining the growing sense of abandonment even among the BJP ranks.

The cost of this inaction is apparent: a state increasingly fractured along ethnic lines, and a pervasive lawlessness that threatens to destabilise the entire region. Without a significant change in strategy, peace will remain an unattainable mirage, with far-reaching implications for the future of Manipur. ■